

The Alcibiades speech I found quite interesting and perhaps slightly performative. Unlike the previous speeches, Alcibiades speech was focused on Socrates rather than Eros. To frame this speech in the context of the others (putting this first because I feel it fits best here) is that for the other speakers were instructed to drink at a rather moderate pace as opposed to Alcibiades who was depicted as being extremely drunk. Alcibiades was then informed that everyone was supposed to give a speech on the god Eros, which Alcibiades used as an opportunity to talk about his interesting relation/view of Socrates.

Alcibiades described Socrates as a silene, which was described as a statue with a sort of plain outside with a divine inside. Then comparing Socrates to Marsyas, saying that Socrates words are like enchanting the enchanting music played by the satyr. However despite this enchanting nature, Alcibiades claims that Socrates also has the ability to make him feel shame like no other. Alcibiades admits that this shame he feels is quite troublesome stating that listening to Socrates compels him to agree with the words Socrates says while simultaneously feeling almost a sense of inadequacy around Socrates. Then Alcibiades then claimed to believe that Socrates was pursuing Alcibiades' "youthful beauty"¹ and wanted to get closer to Socrates under the pretext of acquiring all his knowledge. This however led to some rather strange interactions where Alcibiades was attempting to entice Socrates with different tricks such as wrestling sessions and dinners, eventually leading to Alcibiades professing to Socrates stating that "I think that you alone, I said, are worthy to become my lover"². Alcibiades claims that he would give Socrates anything in exchange for his knowledge and wisdom allowing Alcibiades to become as good as possible. However Socrates denied his proposition stating for him that even if Socrates had this special trait to change Alcibiades then it would be as if Alcibiades is trading "bronze for gold"³, and that Alcibiades should learn to see the good within himself.

Alcibiades then shifts the talk to explain how Socrates is very courageous describing multiple instances of this courage. Such as Socrates trekking through snow barefoot in regular attire as opposed to the other soldiers, being saved by Socrates on the battle field, even while retreating Socrates had this aura of calm and focus about him that allowed him and his comrades to retreat safely. Thus Alcibiades argues this strange combination of traits is unlike any man in past or present which is one of the reasons why Alcibiades compares him to these silenes and satyrs. Infact Alcibiades says that Socrates' arguments are exactly like the silenes where they are outrageous at first because of their words and phrases but when one looks inside the argument they find it to be perfectly logical and the "only arguments with any sense in them" [168], and somehow pertain to "all things worth considering for one who intends to be noble and good" [168]. Alcibiades ends his speech with a warning to Agathon to not be deceived and to learn through his own experiences.

In short, the overall structure of Alcibiades may come across as a drunkard's rant riddled with complaints and praise but Alcibiades has some fairly cohesive structure in his speech. He opens by comparing Socrates to the silene statue and a satyr which is referenced a fair share

¹Plato, *The Symposium*, in *The Dialogues of Plato*, vol. 2, trans. (New Haven: Yale University Press), 163.

²Plato, *Symposium*, 164.

³Plato, *Symposium*, 168.

throughout the speech. He then follows this up with the very concrete examples of how he felt deceived by Socrates as well as how Socrates was courageous.